worrying, the strain found in samples from Amravati was one that escaped antibodies which was later flagged as a ‘Variant of Concern’ and came to be known as the Delta variant or B.1.617. On ground, it was showing signs that it could be highly transmissible and cause deadly infections in the younger population as well. Whether it was evading vaccines too was yet to be seen. The mutation from Satara was a completely new one too, and researchers who conducted the genome sequencing couldn’t find any body of literature to verify or predict its behaviour.[1] Almost like an exploding time bomb, Amravati and Yavatmal were recording 50 per cent positivity rates within days.[2] The Centre was keeping a close watch on the developments. Dr Shashank Joshi, Padma Shri awardee and member of the Maharashtra COVID-19 Task Force, noted in a conversation with me, ‘What was unusual was that during the first wave, we saw that if one member of the family tested positive for COVID-19 and the other members took abundant precautions, the spread of infection to them could be avoided. During February, in Amravati, Akola and Yavatmal we were seeing that almost all members of the family were testing positive together. Even before genome sequencing was done, we suspected that this change in behavioural pattern could be due to a highly transmissible mutation.’ Dr Paul went a step further to explain the role of mutants in viral transmission, ‘We would like to underline the fact that we do not see attribution of mutant strains to the upsurge of the infection being seen in some districts. But this is work in progress and we will continue to watch the situation with full responsibility. The behaviour of the mutants is being constantly and closely watched in the country and when we are doing sequencing, we are not just looking for these strains, but also looking for an abnormal shift in virus character.’[3] That’s the thing with mutant strains, you can’t really foresee its clinical impact on the general population unless it is out there, spreading. And by then, it is already too late to take any precautionary measures because the wave is upon us. The Maharashtra government ramped up its testing in the high-positivity districts and imposed fresh curbs on movement.

Kerala, too, had turned into a COVID-19 hotspot, with over one-fifth of all cases in India concentrated in the state. A month earlier, in January, in Kerala, the Alpha variant had been detected in several samples of UK returnees[4] and controlling the highly transmittable variant had become challenging for the state machinery. As mentioned earlier, at the time, Alpha